THE PRICE OF DAWN — D100 TWILIGHT CHARACTER GROUNDING TABLE

Varenhold Atmosphere & Ties · Roll 1d100 for sensory anchors, moral weight & campaign memories

I. THE LOST SUN & AMBER ATMOSPHERE (01–10)

01. **[SUN]** You were born under eternal gloom and have never felt direct sunlight. What was the wildest, most unbelievable tale an elder told you about what the sun could do?

02. **[BLUE]** When an elder uses the word 'blue,' what muted color actually appears in your mind's eye compared to the endless charcoal and slate of the sky?

03. **[WARMTH]** What is the warmest natural thing you have ever touched that didn't come from a coal hearth, an amber radiator, or another living body?

04. **[WONDER]** Have you ever stared directly into the blinding core of an amber streetlamp until afterimages flashed? What secret pattern did you hope to glimpse?

05. **[DREAMS]** Varenhold's sky is an unmoving dome of ash. What was the most vivid, disorienting dream of an open, cloudless sky you have ever experienced?

06. **[BLIGHT]** When did you first travel outside the city walls and realize that wild plants in the Dusk Parishes grow pale, twisted, and stunted without true daylight?

07. **[SHADOWS]** An archaic nursery rhyme speaks of 'shadows that vanish beneath your boots at noon.' How does the concept of a disappearing shadow make you feel?

08. **[COLOR]** When examining pre-Twilight tapestries in an old manor or chapel, which forgotten color looked the most unnatural, artificial, or frightening to you?

09. **[MORNING]** What distinct smell signals that 'morning' has arrived in your district, given that daybreak is only marked by cathedral chimes and chimney soot?

10. **[TRADE]** If a mysterious stranger guaranteed you five uninterrupted minutes of genuine, blazing midday summer sun, what prized possession would you trade for it?

II. DAILY SURVIVAL & THE COLD REALITY (11–20)

11. **[FLICKER]** What personal superstition or quiet warding gesture do you reflexively make whenever an amber streetlamp sputters and nearly dies?

12. **[RATIONS]** What is your dependable comfort food when the cold sets into your bones: salted cap-mushrooms, greasy tallow bread, fried river eel, or bitter chicory brew?

13. **[CLOCKWORK]** How do you tell day from night in your quarters when your pocket-watch spring winds down and the windowpane remains permanently dim grey?

14. **[FOG]** Which garment in your travelling kit is permanently damp, stiff with river salt, or stained by the greasy coal fog rolling off the canals?

15. **[WAKING]** What sound jolts you awake in the morning: Lowmark coal dray carts rumbling on cobbles, cathedral tolling bells, or iron-shod Reckoning patrol boots?

16. **[POCKET]** You carry a small, smooth pocket token that you nervously rub when frightened or stressed. What is it, where did you find it, and who gave it to you?

17. **[HEARTH]** What is your favorite hole-in-the-wall tavern in Varenhold where the common-room hearthfire is actually kept roaring hot rather than smoldering?

18. **[SOLITUDE]** Where in this crowded, claustrophobic city do you go when you need to be completely alone, where neither street urchins nor faction spies can find you?

19. **[LAYERS]** How many suffocating layers of boiled wool, quilted linen, or waxed leather do you bundle on every single day just to keep frost from stiffening your joints?

20. **[PURCHASE]** What was the single most exorbitant expense you willingly paid this past winter solely to prevent yourself or someone you care about from freezing to death?

III. SICKNESS, FROST & THE HEALERS (21–30)

21. **[FIRST LOSS]** Who was the first person in your family or circle of friends you watched develop the dry, chalky morning cough of Stage-1 Grey Sickness?

22. **[REMEDIES]** What foul-tasting folk tincture, herbal steam, or boiled-root broth did your elders swear could scour the ash and cold damp out of your lungs?

23. **[SECRET FEAR]** When a sudden coughing fit grips you on a freezing morning, do you secretly inspect your handkerchief for telltale flecks of grey ash before pocketing it?

24. **[CLINIC]** Have you ever set foot inside the Lowmark Healing House? What overwhelming sensory memory—smell of vinegar, sounds of weeping, or sight of cots—lingers with you?

25. **[THE FREEZING]** What was the coldest night you ever survived, and what desperate measure or whose shivering body kept you alive until the morning bells?

26. **[QUARANTINE]** If you noticed a close companion hiding an uncontrollable Stage-2 tremor in their hands, would you report them to quarantine officers or risk harboring them?

27. **[CRUEL RHYME]** What callous street-rhyme or skipping chant do city children sing about victims turning into statues of cold grey ash?

28. **[DAWNBORN HEAT]** Have you ever stood in the physical presence of a Dawnborn and felt the uncanny wave of heat radiating from their skin? Did it comfort or terrify you?

29. **[OLD WOUNDS]** Which old blade scar, frostbitten knuckle, or broken bone aches with a fierce, deep throbbing whenever the biting northern frost rolls over the walls?

30. **[ELIXIR]** If an alchemist offered an illegal draught granting total immunity to winter frost for three months in exchange for all your iron writs, would you take the deal?

IV. AMBER ECONOMY, DEBT & TRADE (31–40)

31. **[CHITS]** How many forged or hoarded amber fuel chits do you currently keep secretly sewn into the hem of your cloak for an unexpected emergency?

32. **[DECEPTION]** What is the most convincing, shameless lie you ever told a Compact quartermaster just to secure an extra half-measure of lamp oil or dry grain?

33. **[SACRILEGE]** Have you ever stolen an amber bead from a public street lantern or roadside shrine? Did you burn it to stay alive, or sell it to a pawn broker?

34. **[RELICS]** What pre-Twilight luxury item—such as parasols, sundials, stained-glass windows, or silk fans—seems completely absurd and wasteful to you today?

35. **[SMUGGLING]** The Compact heavily taxes raw amber glass. Have you ever helped row a skiff under cover of canal fog to smuggle contraband heating fuel?

36. **[INHERITANCE]** What worn tool, piece of furniture, or piece of jewelry did you inherit from a neighbor who died unable to clear their mounting Compact heating debt?

37. **[WINDFALL]** If you suddenly stumbled upon a purse of one hundred gold crowns, would you buy land outside the walls, hoard amber crystals, or hire a carriage out of the valley?

38. **[MERCY]** Which merchant, stall-keeper, or pawnbroker in the Outer Ring knows you by name and quietly cuts you a break when times turn desperate?

39. **[PRIDE]** What is the lowest, most humiliating compromise of personal dignity you have ever witnessed someone accept during a severe mid-winter bread famine?

40. **[LANTERN]** Do you own your own personal, well-maintained amber brass lantern, or have you spent your entire life relying on the borrowed light of others?

V. CITY QUARTERS, STREETS & SHADOWS (41–50)

41. **[DREAD]** Which specific quarter or canal district in Varenhold makes the hair on the back of your neck stand up whenever you must traverse it after fourth bell?

42. **[SHORTCUTS]** What is your secret, unmapped shortcut through the Ashring back alleys when ducking a watch patrol, and what grim secret did you once stumble upon there?

43. **[THE SPIRE]** When you look up at the massive brass catwalks of the Spire, what do you privately believe the Master Astronomers have been concealing up there for fifty years?

44. **[UNDERGROUND]** What terrifying rumor about the flooded subterranean vaults and drowned sluice-gates beneath the canal locks do you secretly suspect is entirely true?

45. **[BRAWLS]** In which rowdy tavern did you get into your very first serious brawl, and what petty, drunken argument over fuel or territory ignited the fistfight?

46. **[DECAY]** Which neighborhood felt like a safe haven to you in your early childhood, and what heartbreaking sight illustrates how badly it has rotted away since?

47. **[OLD STONE]** What weather-worn piece of pre-Twilight stone architecture or carved sun emblem do you pass by every day without even noticing it anymore?

48. **[THE GATE]** If the Ironbell Gate were sealed for an indefinite quarantine tomorrow morning, would you rather be trapped inside the city walls or locked outside in the marsh?

49. **[GRIM BEAUTY]** What is the single most breathtaking, hauntingly beautiful sight you have ever witnessed in Varenhold despite the perpetual ash and gloom?

50. **[BEGGARS]** Which eccentric beggar, street preacher, or veteran do you regularly toss copper marks to, and what bizarre story do they always repeat to you?

VI. FACTIONS, WATCH & DIVIDED LOYALTIES (51–60)

51. **[INSPECTION]** What was your closest, most heart-pounding brush with a Reckoning patrol suddenly demanding travel permits, papers, or weapon inspection?

52. **[HARRAN LECHT]** In your honest, private judgment: is Harran Lecht a ruthless tyrant aiming to enslave Varenhold, or the only pragmatic commander holding back the dark?

53. **[LANTERN VIGILS]** Have you ever stood in the packed crowd during Brother Edoran's midnight lantern vigils? Did the collective chanting make you feel holy or profoundly uneasy?

54. **[THE DAWNLESS]** The Dawnless had their names ceremonially expunged from all civic rolls. What eerie rumor about how they communicate in total silence unnerves you most?

55. **[BRIBES]** If the Solennite Blades offered you a bag of gold coin to quietly inform on the movements of your travelling companions, would you refuse instantly or hesitate?

56. **[KINSFOLK]** Do you have a childhood friend, sibling, or former lover who joined the Reckoning, and can you still look them in the eyes when crossing paths on patrol?

57. **[CORRUPTION]** What blatant act of corruption by a City Councillor, Guildmaster, or Temple Prelate did you witness firsthand in broad daylight without being able to stop it?

58. **[WATCHING]** Have you ever caught the cold, motionless gaze of a Concordance priest watching you intently from the shadows of an alley threshold? What did you do?

59. **[RIGHTEOUSNESS]** Which faction in Varenhold do you consider the most dangerous of all precisely because its leaders genuinely believe they are holy saviors?

60. **[THE CHOICE]** If your life hung by a thread and you were forced to entrust it entirely to one leader, whose word would you take: Ostenveld, Harran Lecht, or Brother Edoran?

VII. FAITH, FORGOTTEN GODS & DESPERATE PRAYERS (61–70)

61. **[WHISPERED GOD]** When you mutter a quiet prayer in the freezing darkness, who do you actually petition: Auris the Wounded Sun, Solenne of the Hearth, or older, nameless deities?

62. **[THE SILENCE]** Do you believe the gods deliberately abandoned Varenhold as punishment for Corven's hubris, or were they simply powerless to prevent the ritual's failure?

63. **[CHARMS]** What small consecrated token, carved sun wheel, or prayer bead do you secretly keep stitched inside your boot or hung on a cord around your neck?

64. **[BLASPHEMY]** What was the most bitter, blasphemous thought about the sun god you ever harbored while shivering beside a dying amber heater on a winter night?

65. **[THE CATHEDRAL]** Have you ever knelt in the cavernous nave of Auris Cathedral watching tallow smoke drift across cold stone? What impossible miracle did you pray for?

66. **[THE PULPIT]** When cathedral priests thunder from their pulpits that 'dawn will break for the righteous,' does it bring genuine hope to your chest or a bitter taste of contempt?

67. **[AFTERLIFE]** In your heart of hearts, do you believe souls who die under this perpetual twilight reach a sunlit paradise, or are they trapped forever in the freezing mists?

68. **[FADED RITES]** What seasonal festival, feast day, or solstice ritual does your household stubbornly continue to celebrate, even though celestial cycles have been dead for fifty years?

69. **[WAYSIDE ALTARS]** What is the strangest, most disturbing roadside shrine or makeshift altar of ash and bones you have ever discovered out in the mist-choked marshes?

70. **[THE CONFRONTATION]** If the sun god Auris materialized before you right now and granted you a single question, what furious or desperate accusation would you demand he answer?

VIII. FAMILY, MEMORY & CHILDHOOD (71–80)

71. **[SHADOW GAMES]** What childhood game did you and the neighborhood kids invent that relied on darting between pools of amber lamplight through deep, swallowing shadows?

72. **[ORCHARDS]** Which elderly relative wouldn't stop reminiscing about crisp green apples, sweet pears, and golden grain from before the Year of Ash until everyone grew sick of hearing it?

73. **[SHIELDING]** What harsh, ugly truth about life under the Twilight did your parents try desperately to shield you from, only for you to discover it on your own before age twelve?

74. **[VANISHED]** Think of a close childhood friend who abruptly vanished: did the Grey Sickness take them, did their family flee in the night, or were they recruited by a faction?

75. **[FIRST LIE]** What was the very first lie your parents or guardians told you about the twilight sky so you wouldn't wake up screaming from fear of the encroaching dark?

76. **[HEIRLOOMS]** What single physical keepsake from your mother, father, or mentor do you carry with you everywhere, and what memory does it awaken when you hold it?

77. **[THE HEARTH]** Did you grow up in a wealthy manor with ample coal and glass-paned radiators, or in a drafty tenement shivering beneath four damp wool blankets?

78. **[BITTER WORDS]** What were the last sharp, regretful words you spoke to a member of your family before an estrangement, sudden departure, or death fell between you?

79. **[MENTOR'S RULE]** What ruthless rule of survival drilled into you by an early teacher, master, or parent has kept your heart beating while others around you perished?

80. **[PURE JOY]** When was the last time you laughed until your ribs ached and tears came to your eyes, and who was sitting beside you in the room when it happened?

IX. MORAL COMPROMISE, SECRETS & GUILT (81–90)

81. **[WINTER THEFT]** What is the most morally reprehensible thing you have ever done to ensure that you or someone who depended on you had enough food or fuel to survive winter?

82. **[THE EQUATION]** If the ritual explicitly required sacrificing one innocent person to guarantee restoring the blazing sun to 300,000 citizens: does your conscience say yes, or refuse?

83. **[HIDDEN PAST]** What dark deed, cowardice, or treason from your past history do you pray with every fiber of your being that your fellow party members never uncover?

84. **[BROKEN OATHS]** Have you ever solemnly sworn an oath before witnesses and then deliberately broken it because keeping your word would have destroyed you?

85. **[THE ABANDONED]** Who is the one person you secretly believe you utterly failed when they needed your courage, strength, or presence more than anything in the world?

86. **[UNCONDITIONAL TRUST]** Which companion at your side right now do you trust so completely that you would willingly leap into a blazing inferno if they shouted for you to jump?

87. **[BREAKING POINT]** Which of your travelling companions do you secretly fear is carrying an agonizing private sorrow that will inevitably snap their sanity under pressure?

88. **[THE ABSOLUTE LINE]** What single moral line will you refuse to cross under any circumstance, no matter how catastrophic the failure or how terrifying the stakes?

89. **[IN THE DARK]** When you must end a living enemy's life in the cold shadows, what internal justification or comforting lie do you tell yourself to cleanse your conscience?

90. **[FINAL REGRET]** If your life ends violently tonight on the cold stones of the Ashring, what profound confession or unexpressed love would you grieve leaving unsaid?

X. THE DAWNBORN, CLIMAX & THE FINAL CHOICE (91–100)

91. **[THE BURDEN]** Ten living souls carry the trapped essence of the First Dawn burning in their veins: when you look at them, do you feel awe, envy, or profound pity?

92. **[TOMAS ARETH]** Tomas Areth has spent forty agonizing years obsessively verifying star charts and runes: what words would you say to bring peace to his trembling hands?

93. **[THE BLACKSMITH]** Aldric Stone's eyes blaze with pure amber fire and his body radiates intense, genuine summer heat: does standing near him comfort you, or unnerve you?

94. **[COERCION]** If a terrified Dawnborn weeps on the Ashring steps and says 'I refuse to burn for your city'—could you physically force them onto their stone, or let dawn fail?

95. **[THE MORROW]** When the real sun finally breaks over the mountains tomorrow: do you envision the people dancing in the streets with tears, or turning on each other in panic?

96. **[ECONOMIC RUIN]** The moment true daylight returns, the compact amber monopolies will collapse overnight: whose financial or social ruin will you take grim pleasure in watching?

97. **[A PEACEFUL WORLD]** If the bitter struggle for daily survival finally ends and the sky is bathed in warm light, what will you actually do with your life once you put down your weapon?

98. **[FEAR OF LIGHT]** What is the most unsettling fear you harbor about the true sun: are you secretly terrified that in full, uncompromising daylight you won't recognize who you've become?

99. **[IXA'S HANDS]** Young Ixa's fingers are always warm to the touch like summer river stones: what part of her stubborn innocence and will to live mirrors your own survival?

100. **[THE PRICE]** The First Ritual demanded blood, consent, and sacrifice; if dawn has an absolute price, and someone in this circle must pay it to the end... why not you?